# Bonobo Momma

## By Joyce Carol Oates

**DAUGHTER:** That day, I met my "estranged" mother in the lobby of the Carlisle Hotel on Fifth Avenue, New York City. It was a few weeks following the last in a series of surgeries to correct a congenital malformation in my spine, and one of the first days when I could walk unassisted for any distance and didn't tire too quickly. This would be the first time I'd seen my mother since Fall Fashion Week nearly two years ago. Since she'd divorced my father when I was eight years old my mother, whose professional name was Adelina, spent most of her time in Paris. At 30 she'd retired from modeling and was now a consultant -- a much more civilized and rewarding occupation than modeling, she said. For the world is "pitiless" to aging women, even former vogue models.

## INTRODUCTION

*Loneliness in its deepest form emerges not when we are alone, but when we stand beside someone we love and still feel invisible. When words are exchanged but understanding never arrives, when affection is offered yet never quite reaches us. This kind of loneliness is built on hope: the hope of being recognized, valued, and truly seen. But yearning for closeness does not guarantee connection, even if those you yearn for are your own parents. That is when you are left completely and profoundly alone.*

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**DAUGHTER:** As soon as I entered the Carlisle Hotel lobby, I recognized Adelina waiting for me on a velvet settee. On the way to the hotel I'd become anxious that my beautiful mother might wince at the sight of me, as sometimes she'd done in the past, but she was smiling happily at me—joyously—her arms opened for an embrace. I felt a jolt of love for her like a kick in the belly that took my breath away and left me faint-headed. Is that my mother? My—mother? My father too was "famous" in a similar way—he was a painter/sculptor whose work sold in the "high six figures"— famous in contemporary Manhattan art circles but little-known elsewhere.

**ADELINA:** Darling! Look at you—such a tall girl—

**DAUGHTER:** When she leaned back to look at me her mouth worked as if she were trying not to cry. Adelina

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had not been able to visit me in the hospital at the time of my most recent operation though she'd sent cards and gifts to my room at the Hospital for Special Surgery overlooking the East River: flowers, candies, luxurious stuffed animals and books more appropriate for a younger girl.

**ADELINA:** Your back, darling -- you are all mended? Yet so thin. But you are very pretty. Or would be if – *(inspects her daughter's hair with her hands and is not impressed)* A haircut, chérie. This very day! You're hungry for lunch, I hope *(she turns away)* Come!

**DAUGHTER:** Even in my desperation I was wary, hesitant. With my S-shaped spine that had caused me to walk oddly, I had always been shy and uncertain. Other girls my age hoped to be perceived as beautiful -- I was grateful not to be stared at.

We were going to eat in the sumptuous hotel restaurant. Adelina had made a "special reservation." As the maitre d' was seating us, it appeared that something was amiss.

**ADELINA:** No. I don't like this table.

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**DAUGHTER:** In her throaty aggrieved voice Adelina was telling the maitre d' that she'd made a reservation for a "quiet" table -- her daughter had had "major surgery" just recently. In a voice heavy with sarcasm . . .

**ADELINA:** We will go elsewhere, monsieur! Merci beaucoup!

**DAUGHTER:** In the park, Adelina lit a cigarette and exhaled bluish smoke in luxurious sighs as if only now could she breathe deeply. Her mood was incensed, invigorated. Snugly she linked her arm through mine. I was having trouble keeping pace with her but I managed not to wince in pain for I knew how it would annoy her.

**ADELINA:** Lift your chin, chérie. Ignore if they stare.

**DAUGHTER:** I was hoping that she wouldn't confront anyone. There was a fiery sort of anger in my mother, that was fearful to me, yet fascinating.

Because of her enormously busy professional life that involved frequent travel to Europe, Adelina had relinquished custody of me to my father at the time of their divorce. It had been a "tortured" decision, she'd said. But "for the best, for all." Now when she questioned me about school, I sensed that she wasn't

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really listening. Several times she turned to glare at someone who'd passed us saying sharply . . .

**ADELINA:** Yes? Is there some problem? My daughter would appreciate not to be stared at. Merci!

**DAUGHTER:** Truly I did not know if people were watching us -- either my mother or me -- but it would not have surprised me. Adelina dressed like one who expects attention, yet seemed sincere in rebuffing it. As a child with a body that had been deformed until recently, I'd become accustomed to people glancing at me in pity, or children staring at me in curiosity, or revulsion; but now with my repaired spine that allowed me to walk more or less normally, I did not see that I merited much attention.

Inside the Boat House many diners were awaiting tables. We were jostled by strangers in a continuous stream into and out of the dining area.

My mother inquired about my surgery, and about the surgeon; she seemed genuinely interested in my physical therapy sessions and she explained why she

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hadn't been able to fly to New York to visit me in the hospital, and hoped that I understood. (I did! Of course.)

**ADELINA:** My life is not so fixed. Not like your father!

**DAUGHTER:** My father loved me very much, he said. Still, I saw that he'd begun to lose interest in me once my corkscrew spine had been repaired, and I was released from the hospital: my medical condition had been a problem to be solved, like one of my father's enormous canvases or sculptures, and once such a problem was solved, his imagination detached from it. I could understand this, of course. I understood that, apart from my physical ailments, I could not be a very interesting subject to any adult.

More than a half-hour had passed, and we were still waiting to be seated for lunch. Abruptly then my mother decided that we were leaving. She pulled me outside with her. Again she snugly linked her arm through mine.

**ADELINA:** *(taking sudden notice)* Your shoulder! Your left, you carry it lower than the other. You don't want to appear hunchbacked. What was he? Quasimodo? A terrible thing for a girl. Here . . .

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**DAUGHTER:** Adelina gripped my wrists and pulled them over my head, to stretch me. I was made to stand on my toes, like a ballerina.

**ADELINA:** I don't like how people look at you. With pity, that is a kind of scorn. I hate that!

**DAUGHTER:** Her mouth was wide, fleshy. Her forehead was low. Her features seemed somehow in the wrong proportions and yet the effect of my mother was a singular kind of beauty, it was not possible to look away from her. My father once painted a series of portraits called *Bonobo Momma.* Enormous canvases with primitive figures of monkey-like humanoid females. It was possible to see my beautiful mother in these simian figures with their wide fleshy mouths, low brows, My father had paid homage to that, in my mother. Perhaps it was his loathing of her that had allowed him to see her clearly.

I was feeling light-headed. But when Adelina asked me if I was all right, quickly I told her I was fine.

**ADELINA:** Frankly, darling, you don't look 'fine.' You look sick. Darling, if you could walk straighter. This shoulder . . . try! *(shakes her head in disgust)*

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**DAUGHTER:** I was trying to explain. As in a dream in which the right words won't come . . . Her ash-blond hair stirred in the wind, stiffly. At the base of her throat was a delicate hollow I had not seen before. The bizarre thought came to me, I could insert my fingers into this hollow. I could push down, using all of my weight. My mother's brittle skeleton would shatter.

**ADELINA:** You shouldn't have come out today, darling. If you're not really mended.

**DAUGHTER:** Briskly Adelina was signaling for another taxi. Her manner was urgent, dramatic. A taxi braked to a stop. Adelina opened the rear door, pushed me inside, leaned into the window to instruct the driver

**ADELINA:** Please take my daughter home. She'll tell you the address. She's just 13, she has had major surgery and needs to get home, right away. Make sure she gets to the actual door, will you? You can wait in the street and watch her. *(stooping to kiss her daughter's cheek)* Darling, goodbye! Take a nap when you get home. You look ghastly. I'll call you. I'm here until Thursday. Au-voir!

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**DAUGHTER:** The taxi sprang forward. On the curb my mother stood blowing kisses after us. In the rear view mirror the driver's narrowed eyes shifted to my face. Now I was alone. I wiped at my eyes. Through the smudged window beside me flowed a stream of strangers on the sidewalk -- all that I knew in my life that would be permanent, and my own.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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